

Artifact 3: Open Letter to Social Media Platforms (Project 3, Genre 2)

AN OPEN LETTER

To the Product & Trust and Safety Teams

Instagram · TikTok · Snapchat

July 2026

To the Product and Trust & Safety Teams at Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat,

Your platforms have built extraordinary tools for connecting people to the creators and brands they care about. That same design is quietly draining the finances of your youngest adult users. Young adults ages 18 to 29 are far more likely than any other age group to follow influencers, and the purchases that follow are driven by identification with a creator or brand, not a failure to recognize marketing (Croes & Bartels, 2021; Faverio & Anderson, 2022). This identification effect is strongest where sustained engagement runs highest (Phua et al., 2017), meaning the design choices that make your platform successful also make this pattern difficult to interrupt. Your users already know a countdown timer is a sales tactic. What they lack is a practiced moment to pause before the purchase completes, a moment your checkout flow currently removes rather than provides.

You might reasonably argue that added friction will reduce conversion and hurt a user experience your product teams have spent years optimizing. That concern is fair, but it assumes friction and trust are opposites. A single optional confirmation screen, similar to prompts you already use for account deletion or privacy changes, costs a user ten seconds, not a completed sale. Users who value the pause will use it; users who do not need it can disable it in one tap.

Financial habits change most reliably when an intervention sits at a real decision point, not in a classroom disconnected from any purchase (Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, 2016). We are asking you to build that decision point into your own product: a brief, optional-to-disable confirmation screen for users under 30 before a purchase completes from a creator-tagged post. This is a small design change with precedent in your own confirmation flows, and it would cost your users nothing but ten seconds.

A concerned user and finance student